

Duchamp

In his lifetime, French-born artist Marcel Duchamp (1887–1968) produced relatively few works. But, along with Picasso and Matisse, he helped to define some of the most revolutionary artistic developments during the 20th century and became one of its most influential artists.

Although inspired at first by Matisse and the Fauves, by the First World War, he had rejected the work of many of his contemporaries. His *Nude Descending a Staircase, No.2* created a sensation at the 1913 Armory Show in New York, and the following year he began creating 'readymades' – ordinary objects that he occasionally altered and presented as works of art. In 1917, at the Society of Independent Artists in New York, he exhibited *Fountain*, an upside-down urinal, signed 'R. Mutt'. The controversial work raised questions about how much involvement an artist should have in actual making of art, what constitutes art, and its nature and status. Duchamp argued that using prefabricated objects freed him from the 'trap' of developing a particular style or taste.



Duchamp, *Fountain* (replica), 1917 original